



English AI
Local Coach

ENGLISH AI · THEORY LESSON

Complaints, Returns & Customer Service

Vocabulary, useful phrases, grammar, writing and conversation practice

Level A2-B1 · 45-60 min · Lesson 16

LESSON GOAL

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to explain a problem with a product or service, make a polite complaint, request a refund or replacement, understand common return vocabulary, and negotiate a reasonable solution.

Learn the problem and service vocabulary first, then practise polite complaint structures. Finish with the Conversation Lab by resolving an incorrect order and a defective product.

Communication goal

A strong complaint is calm and specific: explain what you bought, what went wrong, what evidence you have, and what solution you want.

[START HERE](#)

Lesson map

A simple sequence: learn the key language, practise the structure, and then use it in a realistic conversation.

01

LEARN

Vocabulary + useful chunks

02

BUILD

Grammar + model dialogue

03

SPEAK

Writing + role-play

Warm-up

1. Have you ever returned a product? Why?
2. What is the difference between a refund and an exchange?
3. What makes customer service good or bad?
4. Is it easy for you to complain politely in English?

Before you continue

Answer the four questions in English using short sentences. Do not worry about mistakes yet. The goal is to activate the topic before studying the new language.



VOCABULARY 01

Essential vocabulary

Study the meaning and then read each example aloud. Try to connect each word to a real situation from your own life.

WORD / PHRASE	MEANING	EXAMPLE
customer service	atendimento ao cliente	I contacted customer service.
receipt	recibo / nota	Do you still have the receipt?
order	pedido	My order arrived yesterday.
delivery	entrega	The delivery was two days late.
refund	reembolso	I would like a refund.
exchange	troca	Can I exchange this for another size?
replacement	substituição	They sent a replacement product.
return	devolução	The store accepts returns within thirty days.
return policy	política de devolução	Check the return policy first.
warranty	garantia	The product is still under warranty.
defective	com defeito	The device appears to be defective.
damaged	danificado	The box arrived damaged.
missing	faltando	One item is missing from the order.
incorrect	incorreto	I received the incorrect item.
charge	cobrança	There is an extra charge on the invoice.
solution	solução	I would like to find a solution.



VOCABULARY 02

Complaint and resolution language

Use these expressions to separate the problem from the solution you are requesting.

EXPRESSION	MEANING	EXAMPLE / USE
arrived damaged	chegou danificado	The product arrived damaged.
stopped working	parou de funcionar	It stopped working after two days.
wrong size	tamanho errado	You sent the wrong size.
missing item	item faltando	There is a missing item in the package.
charged twice	cobrado duas vezes	I was charged twice for the same order.
request a refund	solicitar reembolso	I would like to request a refund.
ask for a replacement	pedir substituição	Can I get a replacement?
exchange for	trocar por	Can I exchange it for a larger size?
return label	etiqueta de devolução	Please send me a return label.
proof of purchase	comprovante de compra	Do you have proof of purchase?
under warranty	na garantia	The product is still under warranty.
resolve the issue	resolver o problema	How can we resolve this issue?

Study tip

Learn complete expressions, not only isolated words. In conversation, retrieving a ready-made chunk is much faster than building every sentence from zero.



USEFUL PHRASES

What to say in real situations

These phrases are designed to be spoken. Read them aloud and imagine the exact situation where you would use each one.

SITUATION	PHRASE	USE / MEANING
Explain problem	I am contacting you about order #...	Identify order.
	The item arrived damaged.	State problem.
	I was charged twice for the same purchase.	State billing problem.
Request	I would like to request a refund.	Ask for refund.
	Could you send a replacement?	Ask replacement.
	Can I exchange it for a different size?	Ask exchange.
Clarify	What is your return policy?	Ask rules.
	Do I need to pay for return shipping?	Ask cost.
	How long will the refund take?	Ask timing.
Negotiate	That solution works for me.	Accept solution.
	Is there another option?	Ask alternative.
	Could you please escalate this issue?	Request higher support level.

Make it yours

Choose three phrases from this page and rewrite them with details from your own life. Personal examples are easier to remember and use naturally.

GRAMMAR FOCUS

Past simple + polite request for a solution

Use the past simple to explain what happened, then use “I would like...”, “Could you...?”, or “Can I...?” to request a solution politely.

PATTERN	EXAMPLE	USE
past simple	The package arrived yesterday.	completed event
past simple	The screen stopped working.	what went wrong
would like	I would like a refund.	polite request
could	Could you send a replacement?	polite action request
can I	Can I exchange it for another size?	ask permission / option

Complaint formula

PURCHASE -> PROBLEM -> EVIDENCE / TIMING -> REQUESTED SOLUTION. Keep the tone calm even when the problem is frustrating.

Mini practice

Complete: The package _____ damaged yesterday. (arrive)

Complete: I would _____ a refund.

Write a polite request for a replacement.

Write one sentence explaining that you received the wrong item.

MODEL DIALOGUE

Returning a defective product

The customer explains the timeline, gives proof of purchase, and asks for a replacement before discussing other options.

AGENT Hello, customer service. How can I help?

CUSTOMER Hi. I bought a wireless speaker from your store last week, and it has stopped working.

AGENT I am sorry to hear that. When did the problem start?

CUSTOMER Yesterday. It worked for about four days, then it would not turn on.

AGENT Do you still have the receipt?

CUSTOMER Yes, I have the receipt and the original box.

AGENT Great. We can offer an exchange or a refund.

CUSTOMER I would prefer a replacement if possible.

AGENT That is fine. We have the same model in stock.

CUSTOMER Do I need to pay anything for the exchange?

AGENT No. Because the product is defective, there is no additional charge.

CUSTOMER Perfect. What do I need to do next?

AGENT Bring the item, box, and receipt to the service desk, and we will replace it.

Ask for the solution you prefer

Do not only describe the problem. Say whether you want a refund, replacement, exchange, repair, or another specific solution.

WRITING PRACTICE 01

Build useful sentences

Translate the sentences into English using the vocabulary and structures from this lesson. More than one answer may be correct.

1. Estou entrando em contato sobre o meu pedido.
2. O produto chegou danificado.
3. Um item está faltando.
4. Eu recebi o tamanho errado.
5. Eu fui cobrado duas vezes.
6. Eu gostaria de solicitar um reembolso.
7. Você pode enviar uma substituição?
8. Posso trocar por outro tamanho?
9. Qual é a política de devolução?
10. Preciso pagar o frete de devolução?
11. Quanto tempo o reembolso vai levar?
12. Existe alguma outra opção?

WRITING PRACTICE 02

Write a customer service complaint

A useful complaint gives the support team enough information to act immediately and makes your preferred outcome clear.

Task: Write 90-120 words about a problem with a product or service. Mention what you bought, when you bought or received it, exactly what went wrong, any useful evidence, and the solution you want.

Try to include some of these:

- I am contacting you about...
- I ordered / bought...
- It arrived...
- Unfortunately,...
- I have the receipt / photos...
- I would like...
- Could you...?
- Please let me know...

Simple structure

ORDER / PURCHASE -> WHAT HAPPENED -> EVIDENCE -> SOLUTION -> NEXT STEP. Keep emotion low and useful details high.

Self-check before you finish

- ☐ Did I identify the order or product?
- ☐ Did I explain what happened and when?
- ☐ Did I mention evidence such as a receipt or photo?
- ☐ Did I request one clear solution?

CONVERSATION PRACTICE

Role-plays for the AI coach

Open the Conversation Lab and complete each situation before asking the AI to correct you. Try to stay in English even when you need time to think.

Role-play 1 · Wrong delivery

Your online order arrived, but one item is missing and another item is the wrong size. Explain both problems and request solutions.

Role-play 2 · Defective product

A device stopped working after a few days. Ask about warranty, replacement, refund, and the return process.

Role-play 3 · Billing complaint

You were charged twice for a service. Give the amount and date, ask for one charge to be reversed, and confirm how long the correction will take.

Questions to practise

- What is your return policy?
- Can I get a refund?
- Could you send a replacement?
- Can I exchange it?
- Do I need the receipt?
- Who pays for return shipping?
- How long will the refund take?
- Is there another option?

REVIEW

Mini test

Complete this without looking back. The goal is to see what you can produce from memory, not only what you recognize on the page.

1. Translate: reembolso = _____
2. Translate: garantia = _____
3. Translate: danificado = _____
4. Complete: The package _____ yesterday. (arrive)
5. Complete: I would _____ a refund.
6. Translate: “Eu fui cobrado duas vezes.”
7. Translate: “Um item está faltando.”
8. Ask for a replacement politely.
9. Ask to exchange for another size.
10. Ask about the return policy.
11. Ask how long the refund will take.
12. State that you have proof of purchase.
13. Name four possible complaint solutions.
14. What are the four parts of the complaint formula?
15. Write one sentence with “under warranty”.

ANSWER KEY

Check and learn from your mistakes

Some answers can vary. The versions below are natural examples using the language taught in this lesson.

Grammar mini practice

- arrived
- like
- Example: Could you send a replacement?
- Example: I received the wrong item.

Writing practice 01 - Suggested answers

1. I am contacting you about my order.
2. The product arrived damaged.
3. One item is missing.
4. I received the wrong size.
5. I was charged twice.
6. I would like to request a refund.
7. Could you send a replacement?
8. Can I exchange it for another size?
9. What is your return policy?
10. Do I need to pay for return shipping?
11. How long will the refund take?
12. Is there another option?

Review strategy

Mark the sentences that felt slow or uncertain. Say those sentences aloud three times, then create one new example with the same structure.

FINISH

Mini test answers + progress check

Use the score only as a guide. The real objective is to understand the topic and communicate without stopping every time you need a new sentence.

1. refund
2. warranty
3. damaged
4. arrived
5. like
6. I was charged twice.
7. One item is missing.
8. Could you send a replacement?
9. Can I exchange it for another size?
10. What is your return policy?
11. How long will the refund take?
12. I have proof of purchase.
13. refund, replacement, exchange, repair
14. purchase, problem, evidence/timing, requested solution
15. Answers vary.

READY FOR CONVERSATION?

If you can do these four things, move to the Conversation Lab.

- ✓ Explain a product or service problem clearly.
- ✓ Use past simple to describe what happened.
- ✓ Request a refund, replacement, exchange, or other solution politely.
- ✓ Understand common return and warranty vocabulary.

Next lesson suggestion: Future lesson: Hobbies, Entertainment & Invitations